

2026 Annual Report



Defending human rights where dictators rule — a year of releases, launches, and freedom tech.

“I believe the dictatorship has to end, and the Castro dynasty has to end, as well. Because as long as there is a Castro in power, there will be corruption.” — Luis Manuel Otero Alcántara, Cuban artist and prisoner of conscience, upon his release into exile in July 2026 after five years of imprisonment, following HRF's WGAD petition and advocacy

Dear friends,

In July, after 266 days in a Chinese prison, Pastor Ezra Jin walked free — his case raised directly between presidents because thousands of people refused to let his name be forgotten. That same month, the Cuban artist Luis Manuel Otero Alcántara was forced into exile rather than spend one more day in prison — and told the world what every dictator fears to hear: the dictatorship has to end.

These two men have never met. They were born into different countries, languages, and faiths. Yet they are part of a single story, and it is the story of this report: isolation is the dictator's favorite weapon, and connection is the dissident's answer.

This year we gave that answer a sharper map. In February, HRF launched the Tyranny Tracker, a public classification of 179 countries and territories by the honest names of their governments — democratic, hybrid, or fully authoritarian. Naming tyranny is not pessimism. It is the beginning of strategy, because no government should be able to hide what it is behind what it calls itself.

The instruments of defiance multiplied as well. At our Agent Camps, activists from Venezuela to Iran deployed open-source AI agents that draft, translate, and organize faster than any censorship office can keep up. Through our Financial Freedom program, human rights defenders hold money no dictator can freeze. And when our "Power Plays" podcast carried the authoritarian history of the World Cup to more than 100,000 listeners, sport became an argument that dictators could not control.

In Oslo, under the midnight sun, the Freedom Fellowship grew to 76 leaders across 37 countries, and the Oslo Freedom Forum gathered advocates from 111 countries — journalists and pastors, rappers and lawyers, each one proof that the instinct to be free does not respect borders.

None of this happened because it was easy. It happened because dissidents took risks that most of us cannot imagine, and because people like you refused to look away. HRF is proud to be their instrument. The heroes are the ones who sign their names in defiance, and they appear on nearly every page that follows.

To every dictator reading this: your walls are lower than they look, and your prisoners are your best ambassadors of freedom. To every reader: the isolated are connecting. Join them.

Thor Halvorssen
Chief Executive Officer

Céline Assaf-Boustani
President

Wins & Highlights

2026

January

At Bitcoin Park in Austin, HRF's first AI Hack for Freedom paired eight dissidents from Venezuela, Russia, China, and beyond with top open-source developers to build tools for activists through vibe coding. Due to the success, three more followed throughout the year.



April

Nine Freedom Fellows received 30+ hours of training at a working retreat in Brussels and met the European Parliament's Subcommittee on Human Rights.

HRF hosted three days of "Freedom Go Up" programming at Bitcoin 2026 in Las Vegas with Jeff Booth, Anaïse Kanimba, Lisa Neigut, Matt Odell, and Farida Nabourema, plus a mainstage panel with Evan Mawarire and Srdja Popović.



May

After its Miami Beach debut, HRF's "Doors to Freedom" public art installation stood in Rådhusplassen, one of Oslo's busiest public squares, in the run-up to OFF — introducing eight persecuted artists to a mass audience.



Jan.

Feb.

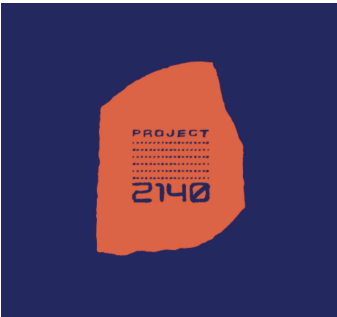
March

April

May

January

More than 50 activists and developers gathered in Nosara, Costa Rica for Project 2140, stress-testing Bitcoin's governance risks, scaling trade-offs, and decentralization. At the gathering, Andreas M. Antonopoulos was announced as the Finney Freedom Prize laureate — awarded with the Finney family for foundational contributions to Bitcoin education and self-custody.



February

HRF publicly launched the Tyranny Tracker, its global democracy index, before 229 attendees at the Freedom Tower in New York — featuring Francis Fukuyama — classifying 179 countries and territories.

HRF launched Agent Camps, an initiative where the world's most prominent human rights defenders learn to deploy and use their own open-source personal agents to supercharge their work.



March

HRF privately urged Doja Cat to cancel her Move Afrika concert in Kigali, then made the letter public, calling out a regime that restricts Rwandan artists and backs atrocities in eastern Congo. The post drew nearly 400,000 views on X.

Sports & Dictators lead Karim Zidan won the J. Anthony Lukas Work-in-Progress Award for his forthcoming book "In the Shadow of the Cage," on mixed martial arts and strongman politics.



Wins & Highlights

2026

June 1–3

The 2026 Oslo Freedom Forum gathered nearly 1,600 participants from 111 countries under the theme "Dismantling Dictatorship." Nobel Peace Prize laureate María Corina Machado addressed the forum in person for the first time.



August 8–15

Twenty frontline defenders gathered at Blue Spirit in Nosara, Costa Rica, for HRF's first Resilience Retreat — a trauma-informed week of rest and peer support marking the launch of HRF's newest program.



October

The Global Freedom Tech Summit returned to Nashville (Oct. 6–9) which brought technologists, activists, philanthropists, and educators together to discuss how technology can be used to accelerate freedom.



June

July

Aug.

Sept.

Oct.

Nov.

Dec.

July 4

Pastor Ezra Jin, founder of one of China's largest underground house churches, was released after 266 days in detention, following HRF's UN petition and a campaign amplified to more than 650 Congressional staffers ahead of President Trump's meeting with Xi Jinping, who raised the case directly.

June–August

"Power Plays," Karim Zidan's five-part podcast on the World Cup and authoritarianism, became the most popular podcast HRF has ever launched — 100,000+ downloads and a featured spot on Apple Podcasts' homepage.



September

With the National Endowment for Democracy, HRF brought ten leading defenders to Washington, D.C. for Agent Camp VII — followed by the third AI Hack for Freedom and Freedom Tech DC. The College Freedom Forum came to Europe for the first time on Sept. 25 in Berlin.



November

The second AI for Individual Rights Summit convened in San Francisco (Nov. 3–5) which gathered AI industry leaders, human rights defenders, researchers, and community leaders to learn how AI can serve as a tool for freedom.



“I believe the dictatorship has to end, and the Castro dynasty has to end, as well. Because as long as there is a Castro in power, there will be corruption.”

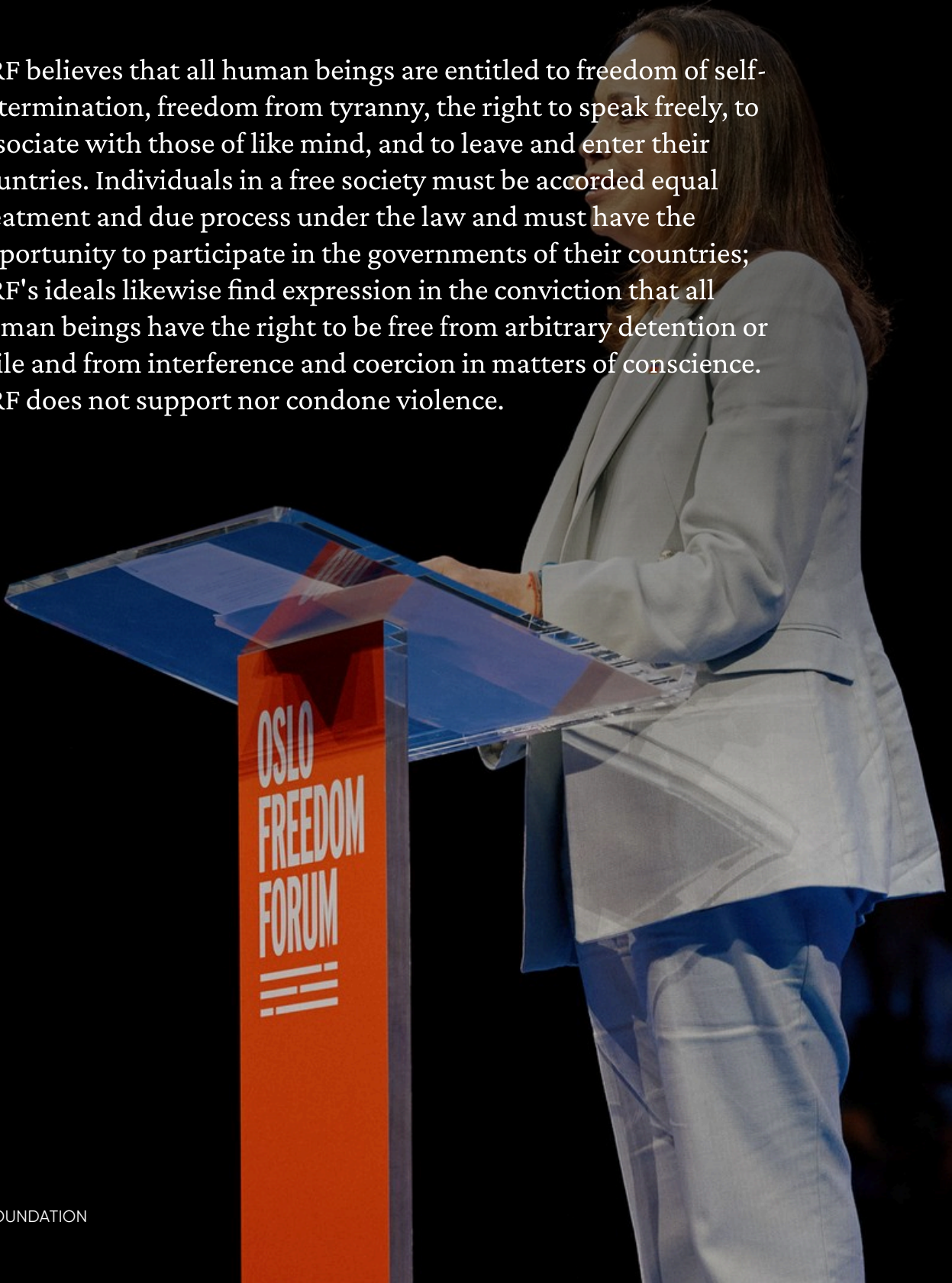
– LUIS MANUEL OTERO ALCÁNTARA
Cuban artist and prisoner of conscience; released into exile in July 2026 after HRF’s advocacy

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The Human Rights Foundation (HRF) is a nonpartisan, nonprofit organization that promotes and protects human rights globally, with a focus on closed societies.

HRF believes that all human beings are entitled to freedom of self-determination, freedom from tyranny, the right to speak freely, to associate with those of like mind, and to leave and enter their countries. Individuals in a free society must be accorded equal treatment and due process under the law and must have the opportunity to participate in the governments of their countries; HRF's ideals likewise find expression in the conviction that all human beings have the right to be free from arbitrary detention or exile and from interference and coercion in matters of conscience. HRF does not support nor condone violence.



HRF Mission



Strategies

Legal Advocacy & Policy Research

HRF produces legal and policy reports, public letters, and impact litigation briefs to defend prisoners of conscience, bring attention to serious human rights violations, and ultimately influence institutions and policymakers.

Global Advocacy & Campaigns

HRF develops and executes innovative campaigns, using new technologies and creative mediums to advocate for democracy and human rights around the world.

Public Education & Events

HRF popularizes the struggle for freedom and democracy through the Oslo Freedom Forum conference series, global events, podcasts, and other educational efforts, bringing human rights into the mainstream of public discussion.

Direct Support

HRF provides human rights advocates with the resources, skills, contacts, and attention they need to make a difference in their countries.

HRF brings attention to the threat of authoritarianism through extensive media coverage, original op-eds, social media advocacy, and informative videos.

In 2026, HRF's work and statements appeared across top international outlets — including more than 1,000 media hits in 125+ countries generated by the Oslo Freedom Forum alone, with coverage in 27 languages.

Media Impact



HRF Op-Eds

HRF's original op-eds shed light on human rights issues and the struggle for liberal democracy around the world.Lawyers are under attack.



Wall Street Journal

Tell Delcy Rodríguez: You're Fired

JAN. 6, 2026

BY THOR HALVORSEN



The Diplomat

Umar Khalid and the Erosion of Indian Justice

JAN. 9, 2026

BY HANNAH VAN DIJCKE & CORINNE KENNY



The Washington Post

Dictators Are Coming for the Lawyers

JAN. 16, 2026

BY YULIA NAVALNAYA

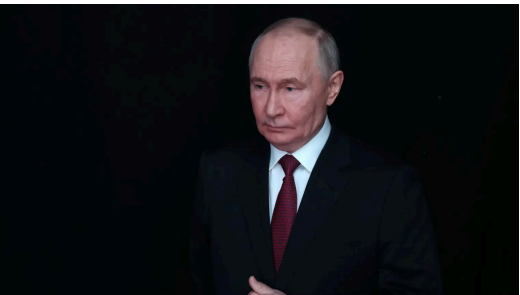


The Moscow Times

Don't Forget the Many Ways Russia Tried to Justify Invading Ukraine

JAN. 30, 2026

BY CASEY MICHEL



Kyiv Independent

We've Overestimated Russia for Too Long

FEB. 27, 2026

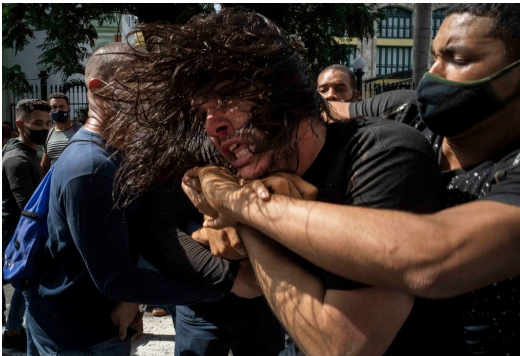
BY CASEY MICHEL



RealClear World

Why Iranians Cannot Simply 'Take Over' Their Government

MARCH 13, 2026
BY HANNAH VAN DIJCKE & CLAUDIA BENNETT



The Washington Post

Trump talks of 'taking Cuba.' Here's what must come first.

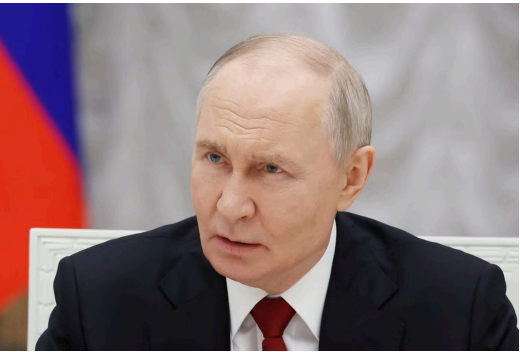
MARCH 19, 2026
BY ROBERTO GONZÁLEZ



The Free Press

Thirty Years Late, Justice Comes Knocking on Raul Castro's Door

MAY 23, 2026
BY ROBERTO GONZALEZ



The Wall Street Journal

Russia Has Lost Its 'Near Abroad'

JUNE 12, 2026
BY CASEY MICHEL



The Wall Street Journal

Decades Late, Cuba Approves Serious Market Reforms

JULY 7, 2026
BY ROBERTO GONZALEZ



Journal of Democracy

How AI Agents Are Empowering Human-Rights Defenders

JULY 22, 2026
BY ALEX GLADSTEIN



Bitcoin's Overlooked Promise: Freedom

SEPT. 4, 2026
BY ALEX GLADSTEIN

The Wall Street Journal

Top Media Coverage

Social Media Hits

HRF's social media videos, visuals, and storytelling sparked global conversations in 2026, inviting new audiences to take action in the struggle for human rights.

January

Grace Jin Drexel's Christmas letter to her father, Pastor Ezra Jin, reached 2,000+ YouTube views — months before his release from Chinese detention.

February

A social reel with Joey Siu marking Hong Kong 47 prisoner Owen Chow's fifth birthday in prison drew 7,800+ views, 445 likes, and 29 reposts.

March

HRF's public letter urging Doja Cat to cancel her Move Afrika concert in Kigali reached nearly 400,000 views on X within days of publication.

June

The 2026 Oslo Freedom Forum generated 7.7 million video views and 350,000 social media engagements across platforms.

June–August

"Power Plays," HRF's five-part podcast on the World Cup and authoritarianism, drew 100,000+ downloads and a featured spot on Apple Podcasts' homepage. The Dissident's Mic interview series launched with Félix Maradiaga, Tutu Alicante, and Jewher Ilham.

Legal and policy initiatives form the backbone of HRF's advocacy work.

The organization's policy specialists monitor and evaluate trends in nations governed by hybrid or fully authoritarian regimes. Through the publication of reports, policy briefs, and blog articles, they seek to raise awareness of widespread human rights violations committed by dictatorships. HRF's team of international lawyers provides pro bono representation to activists, journalists, and other civil society figures persecuted by authoritarian governments. The team also submits emblematic cases to judicial and semi-judicial bodies to achieve justice and accountability.

Legal Advocacy & Policy Research

Sarah Repucci
Senior Research Advisor
Human Rights Foundation

Javier El-Hage
Chief Legal & Policy Officer
Human Rights Foundation

Impact Litigation

Through its Impact Litigation program, HRF's in-house team of international lawyers advocates on behalf of brave individuals before international and quasi-judicial bodies, including the United Nations Working Group on Arbitrary Detention (WGAD). To date, the WGAD has issued decisions on most of the cases submitted by HRF, with every ruling favoring the client.

HRF represents prisoners of conscience whose cases are emblematic of a dictatorship's brutality. Litigation before the WGAD addresses the inadequacies of judicial systems in authoritarian regimes and offers remedies for pursuing justice for victims of corrupt judicial systems.

2026 Submissions & Successes

January | Iran

HRF submitted a petition to the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention on behalf of Hossein Shanbehzadeh, an Iranian system administrator detained for replying to a U.S. president's post on X. His case exemplifies the Iranian regime's practice of jailing citizens for the most ordinary acts of online expression.

January | Venezuela

HRF welcomed the release of Rocío San Miguel, Biagio Pilieri, and Enrique Márquez. San Miguel, a lawyer and founder of Control Ciudadano, is the 2025 Thulani Maseko Justice Prize laureate; she was arrested in February 2024 in a wave of repression that followed Venezuela's stolen election, and HRF had advocated for her release alongside international partners.

January | Russia

HRF submitted a communication on behalf of Vadim Kobzev and Alexei Liptser, two of the attorneys who represented Alexei Navalny, who were themselves imprisoned for the crime of defending him. Their case is part of the Kremlin's systematic destruction of the legal profession.

January | India

HRF filed a petition to the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention on behalf of Irfan Mehraj, a Kashmiri human rights defender and journalist documenting abuses in Indian-administered Kashmir, arrested under India's draconian counterterrorism law.

March | India

The UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention issued a favorable opinion in the case of Umar Khalid, finding his detention arbitrary and in violation of international law. This was HRF's first-ever favorable opinion related to India — a milestone in the program's geographic expansion.

March | Cambodia

The UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention issued a favorable opinion in the case of Koet Saray, a Cambodian land rights and labor activist and president of the now-shuttered Khmer Student Intelligent League Association. His case was also accepted into the Lantos Foundation's Defending Freedoms Project, with Representative Lori Trahan serving as his designated advocate in Congress.

March | Inter-American Court

HRF submitted observations to the Inter-American Court of Human Rights in its landmark advisory proceedings on the climate emergency and human rights, arguing that democracy itself is a precondition for the enjoyment of all other rights and that environmental defenders in authoritarian contexts require heightened protection.

April | China

HRF submitted a petition to the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention on behalf of Gao Zhen, the celebrated Chinese artist detained for his artwork — weeks before he was awarded the Václav Havel International Prize for Creative Dissent at the Oslo Freedom Forum.

May | China

HRF filed a joint submission to the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention on behalf of three Chinese pastors — Jin Mingri, Gao Zhicai, and Wang Yi — persecuted for practicing their faith outside state-controlled institutions.

May | Equatorial Guinea

The UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention issued a favorable opinion in the case of Anacleto Micha Ndong Nlang, an Equatoguinean trade unionist. HRF led a joint statement with Amnesty International, the World Organization Against Torture, and the International League against Arbitrary Detention urging the regime to implement the opinion and release him immediately.

July | Rwanda

The UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention issued a favorable opinion in the case of Victoire Ingabire, Rwanda's most prominent opposition figure, finding her detention arbitrary and in violation of international law. After the 2026 Oslo Freedom Forum, her sons brought a portrait of their mother — painted at HRF's Impact Litigation booth — to the UN Human Rights Council in Geneva during Rwanda's Universal Periodic Review.

July | China

Pastor Jin Mingri was released from a Chinese prison on July 4 — six weeks after HRF filed his WGAD petition, and days after the U.S. government raised his case directly with Xi Jinping. His daughter Grace Jin Drexel's video letter to her father reached more than 650 congressional staffers. The case stands as HRF's model of legal, advocacy, and communications teams operating as one integrated instrument.

July | Crimea

HRF updated its submissions regarding Lenur Danylovyh, the Crimean Tatar journalist and political prisoner, in coordination with Reporters Without Borders. Danylovyh was abducted by Russian occupation forces for his reporting and remains imprisoned in Crimea.

July | Cuba

Luis Manuel Otero Alcántara, Cuba's most prominent political prisoner, leader of the San Isidro Movement, and a 2024 Oslo Freedom Forum speaker, was released on July 21 — into forced exile, after years of imprisonment that HRF documented through WGAD litigation and global advocacy.

Impact Litigation

July | Thailand

The UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention issued a favorable opinion in the case of Sopon "Get" Surariddhidhamrong, a Thai activist prosecuted under Thailand's lèse-majesté law for peaceful expression.

July | Hong Kong

The UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention issued a favorable opinion in the case of Owen Chow, a Hong Kong pro-democracy activist and one of the Hong Kong 47, prosecuted under the National Security Law for organizing primary elections.

August | Pakistan

HRF, together with Freedom House and Hindus for Human Rights, submitted a petition to the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention on behalf of Dr. Mahrang Baloch, the imprisoned Baloch human rights leader, at the Working Group's urgent request. Baloch has become the defining voice of Pakistan's disappeared.

August | El Salvador

HRF, in coordination with Perseus Strategies, filed a petition to the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention on behalf of Ruth López and Enrique Anaya, Salvadoran anti-corruption figures swept up in Nayib Bukele's crackdown on checks and balances.

August | India

Irfan Mehraj was granted bail after 33 months of arbitrary detention — vindication for a defender whose only crime was documenting human rights abuses.

Anticipated Outcomes (Sept–Dec)

The Impact Litigation team is drafting three WGAD submissions — for individuals in Pakistan, Cuba, and Hong Kong — and a submission to the UN Working Group on Enforced and Involuntary Disappearances for a Rwandan individual disappeared in Mozambique.

Universal Periodic Reviews

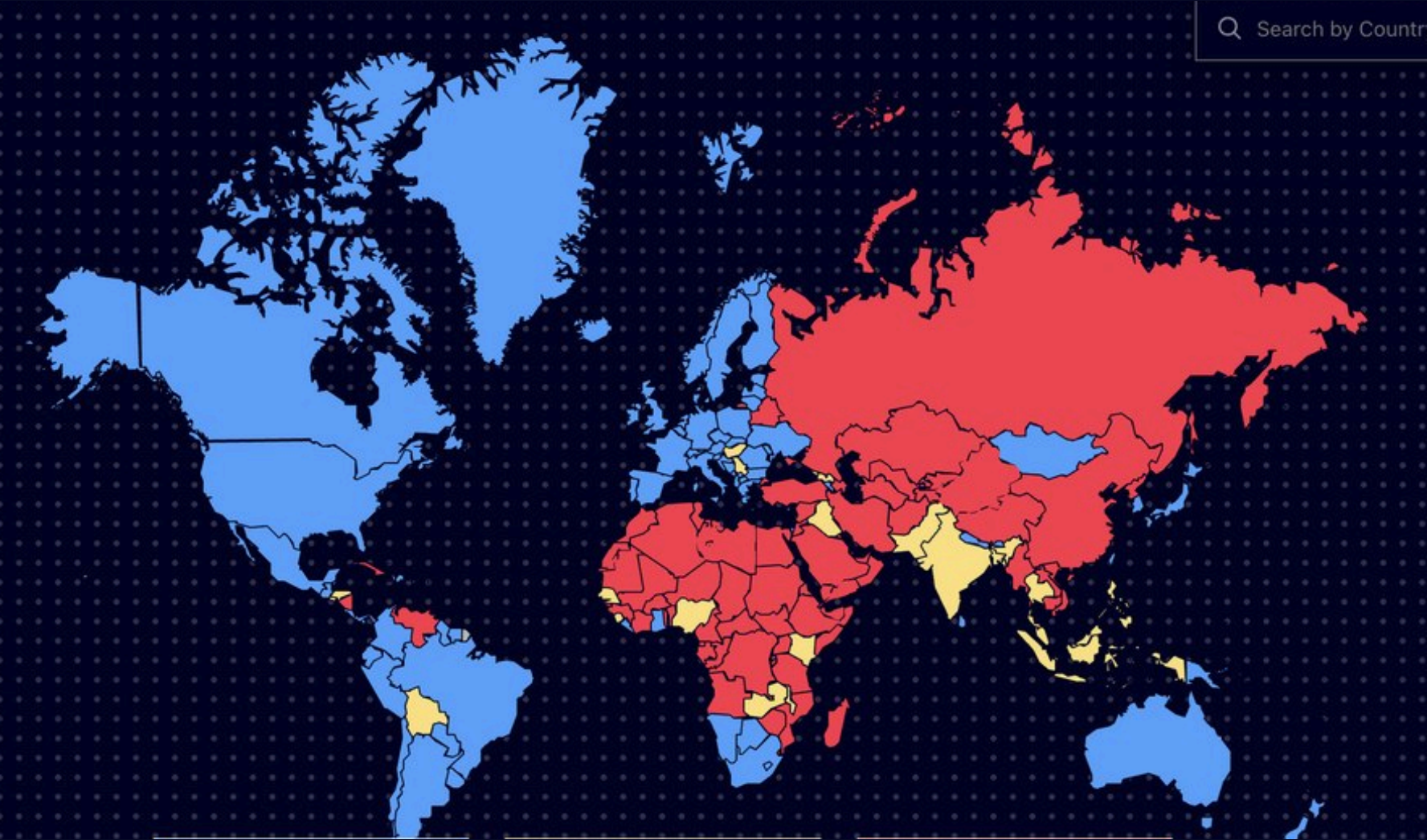
HRF conducts advocacy work through Universal Periodic Review (UPR) submissions to the UN Human Rights Council (UNHRC). UPRs allow NGOs and civil society groups to call for assessments of member states' human rights situations.

To date, HRF has submitted 59 UPRs. HRF completed X Universal Periodic Review submissions in the 2026 sessions of the UNHRC.

Tyranny Tracker

HRF tracks and assesses fundamental democratic freedoms across countries and territories worldwide. Backed by a broad network of local human rights advocates, HRF's internal research team analyzes the presence of electoral competition, freedom of dissent, and institutional accountability in each nation. Using a distinctive qualitative approach, the team categorizes governments as democratic, hybrid, or fully authoritarian.

In February 2026, HRF launched the Tyranny Tracker — the first public-facing version of this global classification. At launch, the platform featured 879 country and territory classifications built by 11 research fellows, spanning 179 countries and territories and 42 indicators of freedom.



Democracies: 106

Governments that largely guarantee free and fair elections, the freedom to dissent, and an independent judiciary.

Hybrid Authoritarian Regimes: 17

Regimes that generally allow for a non-trivial degree of electoral competition and basic political freedoms but deny these democratic rights and fundamental freedoms to a degree that they make a change of government through democratic means very difficult.

Fully Authoritarian Regimes: 55

Regimes that systematically deny their citizens meaningful electoral competition, basic political freedoms, and an independent judiciary willing and capable of checking the regime's ability to repress basic democratic freedoms.



Tyranny Tracker



The Tyranny Tracker quickly became HRF's flagship policy anchor: the team presented it at the National Endowment for Democracy, the University of Oxford, the University of Chicago, Stanford University, and other institutions through the second half of the year. The Washington Post and The Free Press cited it in their own reporting, and an Azerbaijani reader wrote to the team after finding the story of his shuttered media outlet in his country's classification.



The regime response came swiftly: in October, Russia's communications regulator blocked access to the Tyranny Tracker within Russia — and days later, the Russian government designated HRF itself an "undesirable organization," criminalizing any Russian who engages with HRF's work. The team is now expanding next year's edition with at least eight more country classifications and updated indicators, and is publishing four regional reports on transnational repression, the first focused on authoritarian collaboration, scheduled for October 2026.

HRF 2026 Research Spotlight

Since 2018, HRF has expanded its research, publishing blog posts, policy briefs, and in-depth research reports on pressing human rights issues.

How the Regime in Equatorial Guinea Exploits Football



With support from HRF, the Africa program published a report documenting how Teodoro Obiang's regime exploits football to launder its image, featuring exclusive testimonies from former Equatoguinean players. Published in English and Spanish, the report traces how the ruling family captured and politicized football institutions for international prestige, popular distraction, personal enrichment, and the consolidation of a system with no tolerance for dissent. In September, HRF co-organized an event in Barcelona with Panenka magazine and led a joint statement with Amnesty International and the World Organization Against Torture urging the regime to release trade unionist Anacleto Micha Ndong Nlang.

Bitcoin for Nonprofits



In May, HRF's Financial Freedom program published Bitcoin for Nonprofits, the first practical guide for civil society organizations seeking to accept, hold, and deploy bitcoin in repressive financial environments. The guide walks nonprofits through custody, compliance, and operational security, drawing on the experience of organizations operating under dictatorship.

AI for Activists

The AI for Individual Rights team published the AI for Activists handbook — a field guide for human rights defenders on how to use open-source AI tools securely — ahead of schedule in November.

Sustainable Development Goals Report

Authoritarian regimes exploit the UN Sustainable Development Goals to strengthen political control — through selective implementation, propaganda, co-optation, and manipulated reporting that creates the appearance of progress while undermining human rights and democratic governance. HRF's report calls for stronger accountability, independent reporting, and explicit integration of democracy and human rights into the post-2030 framework. The report has been cited across the policy community.

HRF exposes and confronts authoritarian abuses through innovative and multifaceted campaigns.

Initiatives target key industries, such as fashion and sports, while leveraging creative platforms like art and technology. Through strategic partnerships with industry leaders, HRF develops pioneering strategies to challenge and dismantle authoritarian repression.

Global Advocacy & Campaigns



Art in Protest

HRF's Art in Protest program amplifies the voices and creativity of courageous artists living under — or forced into exile from — authoritarian regimes. Through residencies, exhibitions, and international platforms, HRF offers dissident artists opportunities to develop their work and expand their global impact.



2026 Art in Protest Resident Artist

Ugandan artist Leilah Babirye — forced to flee after being publicly outed — joined the Art in Protest Residency with Fountainhead Arts from February to March, hosting studio visits with curators and collectors and generating \$75,000 in artwork sales.

Doors to Freedom Goes to Oslo



Following its Miami Beach debut, the "Doors to Freedom" installation — honoring eight artists censored, imprisoned, or exiled by authoritarian regimes — stood in Rådhusplassen, one of Oslo's busiest public squares, from May 26–31 in the run-up to OFF, with volunteers engaging passersby on artistic freedom.

Let There Be Light



Tenzing Rigdol's exhibition on Tibetan identity and life under Chinese rule ran May 22–June 3 alongside OFF. Art in Protest facilitated a private meeting between Richard Gere and Oslo's Tibetan community.

Looking Ahead (Sept–Dec)

The final quarter will be especially busy for the Combating Kleptocracy team: panels and keynote speeches in Munich, Prague, and the Dominican Republic; reports on corruption in Nicaragua, Angola, El Salvador, Serbia, and Cameroon, plus the NBA's relationship with authoritarians; and the Storython in Lisbon, Portugal — a September convening bringing together anti-corruption activists from Central Africa to examine new ways to investigate and highlight the threats of corruption and kleptocracy.

Combating Kleptocracy

HRF's Combating Kleptocracy program exposes how dictatorships use financial secrecy and influence campaigns to entrench their regimes, smother democratic opposition, and enrich themselves that much further. Through research, public awareness campaigns, and media coverage, HRF has taken a global lead in highlighting the threats of kleptocratic regimes worldwide.

The Dissident's Mic



A new interview series on authoritarianism worldwide launched in mid-2026 — featuring Félix Maradiaga on Nicaragua, Tutu Alicante on Equatorial Guinea, and Jewher Ilham on China and the Uyghurs.

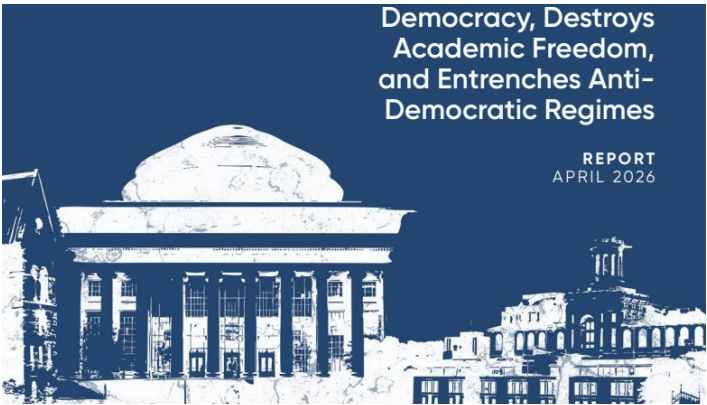
The CCP's Authoritarian Influence on Latin American Democracy

HRF's report analyzes how the People's Republic of China has entrenched itself in Latin America over the past decade — combining economic opportunity with strategic statecraft across financing, diplomacy, security cooperation, and narrative strategies, including disinformation, while working to isolate Taiwan — and presents recommendations for Latin American democracies and their partners to counter democratic erosion.

Documenting Power Online (Sudan)

HRF's report examines how Sudanese activists have used digital tools to expose and challenge external involvement in Sudan's war. Expected publication: second half of 2026.

Dictators and Diplomas: Why Foreign Autocracies Funding American Universities Threaten Democracy, Destroys Academic Freedom, and Entrenches Anti-Democratic Regimes



This first-ever analysis traces nearly \$9 billion in financial flows from authoritarian regimes to leading American universities since 2014. It examines how these gifts, contracts, and joint research centers help dictatorships launder their reputations, influence students and faculty — including those cycling through official positions in the U.S. government — and gain access to sensitive technology, and offers recommendations for universities and regulators.

2026 pipeline (second half)

Transnational repression regional reports (Middle East and North Africa; Asia Pacific; Europe and Central Asia; Africa), an Asia gender-based violence report, the NBA's relationship with authoritarians, and kleptocracy country reports on Nicaragua, Cameroon, and Serbia.



Wear Your Values

HRF's Wear Your Values (WYV) program aims to shed light on the hidden social costs of the fashion industry. Through creative advocacy campaigns and educational exhibitions, WYV raises awareness of forced labor, promotes transparency in global supply chains, and encourages ethical shopping among consumers.

Those interested in collaborating can contact the program at wearyourvalues@hrf.org.



OFF 2026 Roundtable Ethical Merch Milestone

The Transparentem partnership moves HRF and OFF toward a published list of verified forced-labor-free merchandise — which would make HRF and OFF the first NGO and conference series able to claim with certainty that they are supporting ethical supply chains and combating tyranny.

During OFF 2026 in June, WYV convened a private roundtable of industry leaders, activists, NGO executives, and survivors of forced labor to define the program's next front.

UN Engagement & Transparency Partnership

In February, program lead Claudia Bennett met the UN Special Rapporteur on contemporary slavery to map collaboration. WYV also launched a year-long partnership with Transparentem, investigating factories to guarantee that merchandise at OFF and beyond is free from forced labor — making HRF the first conference series able to certify ethical supply chains.

San Francisco Community Fashion Week

In March, Bennett spoke at San Francisco Community Fashion Week on how consumers, designers, technologists, and lawyers can eliminate forced labor from fashion.

Celebrities & Dictators

HRF's Celebrities & Dictators program calls on celebrities, influencers, entertainment brands, and professional sports organizations to reject partnerships with authoritarian regimes. The program encourages public figures to use their reach to challenge dictatorship-driven narratives, shed light on human rights violations, and elevate the voices of those who resist oppression.



Power Plays Podcast



Power Plays is a five-episode series exploring the authoritarian history of the World Cup, from corruption and illicit finance to how dictators use sport to launder their reputations. Launched in May 2026 ahead of the World Cup, the podcast surpassed 140,000 listens and was featured by Apple Podcasts during the tournament. The series earned a J. Anthony Lukas award for HRF's Sports and Dictators work and pairs with the program's football club tracker and Spanish-language distribution partnership.

Doors to Freedom: Art Week Miami

Building on the success of Doors to Freedom, the Art in Protest program, in partnership with Cuban Freedom March, launched a new art installation for Art Week Miami on artistic freedom and authoritarianism — using public art to engage new audiences at one of the world's leading contemporary art events.

Open Letter to Doja Cat



In March, HRF privately urged Doja Cat to cancel her headline performance at the Move Afrika concert in Kigali, then made the letter public — calling out a regime that restricts Rwandan artists and backs atrocities in eastern Congo. The post on X drew nearly 400,000 views.

Open Letter to Will Smith



In May, HRF wrote to Will Smith after he appeared alongside Angolan President João Lourenço and endorsed the regime's tourism campaign, warning against image-laundering for a corrupt government and urging him to amplify Angolan defenders instead.

Celebrities & Dictators

E1 Luanda GP Campaign

In September, HRF launched a campaign with local Angolan organizations during the E1 Luanda Grand Prix to raise awareness of the Angolan regime's human rights record. (details TK)

Shadow Play with the Signal

The Sports & Dictators team's "Shadow Play" project with The Signal. (details TK)

Lukas Award

In March, Sports & Dictators lead Karim Zidan won the J. Anthony Lukas Work-in-Progress Award for his forthcoming book "In the Shadow of the Cage," on mixed martial arts and strongman politics.



Today, billions of people living under authoritarianism lack financial freedom. Dictators frequently debase, manipulate, demonetize, and surveil currencies, confiscate property, and freeze the bank accounts of critics and dissidents.

The Financial Freedom program highlights how authoritarian regimes engage in financial repression to crack down on dissent. Through public education, direct support, and new, open-source technologies, HRF aims to empower activists with financial sovereignty, enabling them to operate freely, expand their movements, and continue their struggle for democracy.



Public Education

Financial Freedom Report

The Financial Freedom Report is HRF's go-to source on the role money and banking play in the civil liberties and human rights of people living under authoritarian regimes. Shared weekly with thousands of readers, the report curates global news and practical resources showing how monetary inventions like Bitcoin help dissidents secure their financial freedom. In 2026, the report passed its 130th edition.

CBDC Tracker

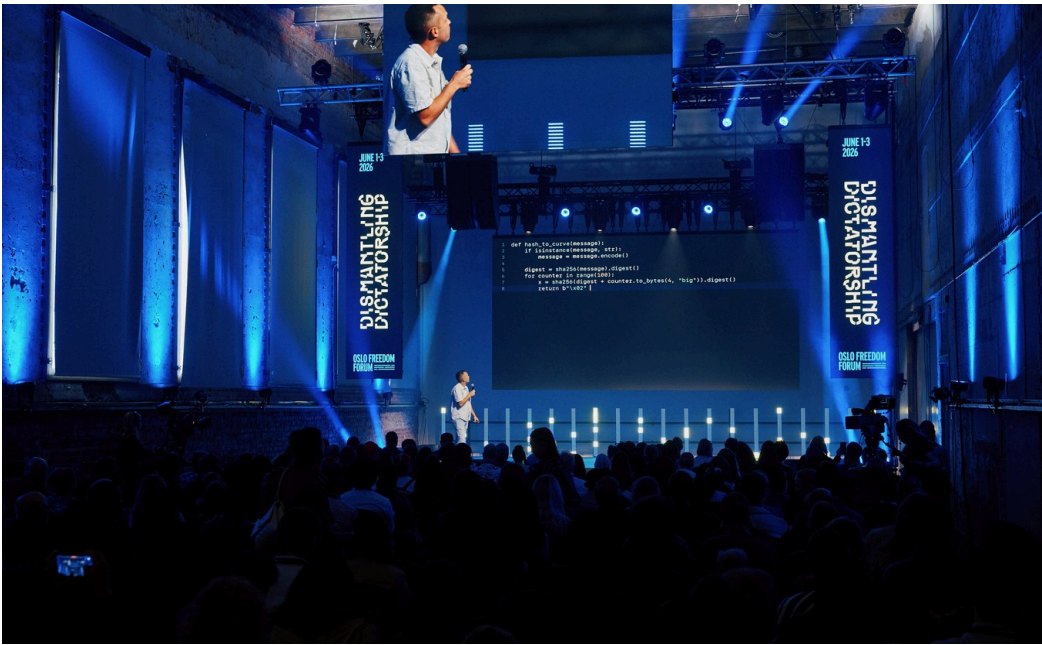
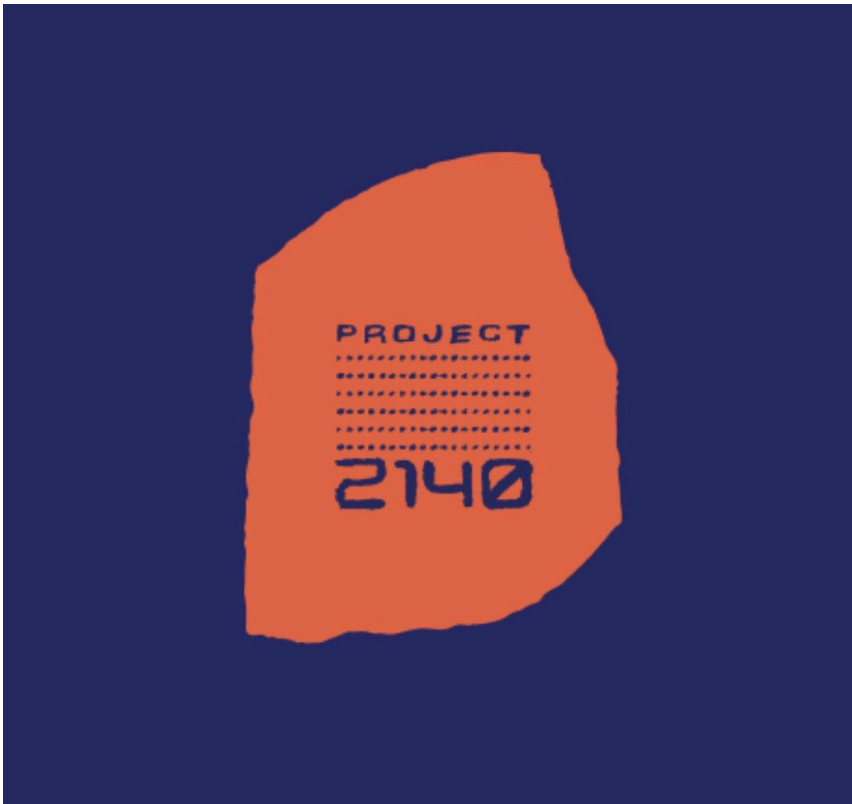
HRF continued to advance its Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) Tracker, the premier resource for monitoring the research, development, and implementation of CBDCs worldwide. In 2025, the Tracker gained recognition from institutions including the Federal Reserve, the Cato Institute, Cornell, MIT, and Johns Hopkins. HRF also presented the tracker at SXSW 2025, underscoring its role in tracking the expansion and risks to civil liberties of these centralizing technologies.



Global Events

Project 2140

From Jan. 6–9, more than 50 activists and developers gathered in Costa Rica to stress-test Bitcoin's governance risks, scaling trade-offs, and decentralization — ensuring it stays a durable tool for freedom.



OFF Freedom Tech Track

In June, HRF brought together developers and human rights defenders to explore how Bitcoin, Nostr, and other freedom tools can counter authoritarian financial repression and protect human rights.



Global Freedom Tech Summit

In October, HRF hosted the Global Freedom Tech Summit at Bitcoin Park in

Nashville, Tennessee. More than 125 human rights defenders, software developers, social entrepreneurs, privacy advocates, educators, community builders, authors, and designers from over 60 countries joined the event. Over three days, attendees examined how technology is emerging as a tool for freedom.

Anticipated Outcomes (Sept–Dec)

Sept. 21–23: HRF hosts its 10th Financial Freedom Webinar, training activists and civil society groups to use Bitcoin under authoritarian regimes, led by HRF's Anna Chekhovich and Win Ko Ko Aung with Bitcoin educator Ben Perrin (BTC Sessions).

Sept. 22–23: HRF showcases its program at Freedom Tech DC, the Bitcoin Policy Institute's two-day summit in Washington.

Oct. 6–9: HRF hosts the fourth annual Global Freedom Tech Summit.

Dec. 1–3: HRF sponsors the Africa Bitcoin Conference in Blantyre, Malawi — founded by Togolese democracy activist Farida Nabourema — advancing Bitcoin education and adoption across the continent.

One more Bitcoin Development Fund grant round is expected before year's end.



Supporting Innovators

Finney Freedom Prize

In January, Andreas M. Antonopoulos received the Finney Freedom Prize — awarded with the Finney family — for foundational contributions to Bitcoin education and self-custody. The announcement was made at Project 2140 in Nosara.



Unstoppable Webinar

Each quarter, HRF hosted Become Unstoppable, a free three-day webinar series teaching human rights organizations and activists practical skills to use Bitcoin safely — helping movements keep receiving donations when governments freeze bank accounts, block donations, or cut organizations off from funding. The webinar builds on HRF's quarterly Financial Freedom webinars and the Bitcoin for Nonprofits guide, giving nonprofits the tools to protect their financial privacy and keep their work running under dictatorship.



Bitcoin Development Fund

In January, the Bitcoin Development Fund distributed 1.3 billion satoshis to 22 projects — privacy, scalability, and censorship-resistance infrastructure serving activists in Azerbaijan, Mozambique, China, and beyond. In March, a Q1 round granted 1.5 billion satoshis to 26 projects, focused on privacy tools and Bitcoin education across Africa and Asia — bringing the year's total to 2.8 billion satoshis across 48 projects.

Bitcoin for Nonprofits



In 2025, HRF created the world's first-ever program designed to expose artificial intelligence used by autocrats as tools of repression and support open-source AI tools in the hands of dissidents. In 2026, the program scaled from launch to full operation — funding tools, training activists, and convening the AI and freedom communities.

This program comes at a moment where AI tools made by Chinese actors with connections to the CCP are some of the most performant in the world, displacing tools made by corporations and associations inside liberal democracies. This is also a time when open-source AI tools have never been more powerful, and the opportunities to use AI tools to strengthen the work that dissidents do inside authoritarian regimes have never been greater.

AI for Individual Rights Fund

HRF has distributed over \$500,000 in grants expanding access to ensure that AI serves freedom. Projects range from research into how authoritarian regimes weaponize AI against their people, human rights defenders using AI to empower their work, and open-source and privacy-protecting that protect defenders under tyranny.

Agent Camps

Three multi-day camps brought more than twenty five of the world's leading activists from Afghanistan, Iran, Venezuela, Bolivia, and beyond to deploy their own open-source AI agents, in partnership with Finite. Agents learn an activist's context, automate workflows, build tools instantly, and serve as a digital ally.





Research

Organizational Brain and Agents

HRF is building out its own AI "organizational brain." This is an AI-powered tool that synthesizes years of organizational knowledge so that staff can get answers instantly without meetings, generate reports, or gain insights. HRF staff is also being onboarded to privacy-protecting AI agents to accelerate their work.



AI for Individual Rights Summit

From Nov. 3–5, HRF convened the second AI for Individual Rights Summit in San Francisco, bringing together human rights defenders, researchers, and open-source technologists to advance private, freedom-enhancing AI.



AI Hack for Freedoms

Four editions of HRF's vibe-coding hackathon paired dissidents with open-source developers in 2026: Austin in January (Hack I), Nashville in May (Hack II), Washington, D.C. in September (Hack III, with the National Endowment for Democracy), and San Francisco in December (Hack IV at Presidio Bitcoin). Across the series, sixteen dissidents from Venezuela, Russia, China, Rwanda, Nicaragua, Hong Kong, Iran, and beyond built tools for activists — including an AI-powered nonviolence training platform, a censorship-resistance tool for anonymous speech, and Roya Mahboob's Roshan, a personalized AI learning companionAI Fun.

CCP Disruption Initiative

Through its Chinese Communist Party Disruption Initiative (CCPDI), HRF raises awareness of the CCP's sustained assault on civil liberties and works to shape public understanding of Xi Jinping's authoritarian rule. The program highlights the regime's repressive tactics and abuses, including corporate coercion, digital surveillance, persecution of Chinese human rights defenders, the Uyghur genocide, the suppression of freedoms in Tibet, and the erosion of rights in Hong Kong.



Beyond Borders Retreat

From March 23–26 in Ghent, Belgium, 30 young activists from the Uyghur, Tibetan, Hong Kong, Chinese, and Southern Mongolian diasporas — and Taiwan — built collective-protection strategies across six expert-led tracks.

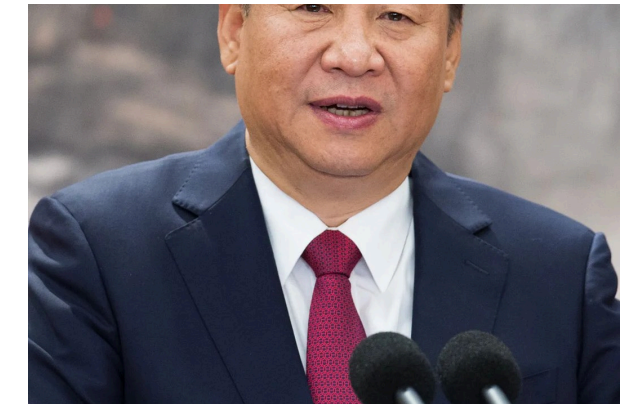
Global Advocacy

In early 2026, CCPDI coordinated a cross-platform statement with Jewher Ilham marking the anniversary of Ilham Tohti's arrest and a joint letter to UN High Commissioner Türk demanding investigation of China's crimes against humanity. A social reel with Joey Siu marking Owen Chow's fifth birthday in prison drew more than 7,800 views.

CCPDI spoke in Sweden and to audiences in Taiwan — in English and Mandarin — on academic freedom, PRC resistance movements, and Uyghur youth resilience, and co-led the Pastor Jin campaign that contributed to his July release.

In March, HRF signed a joint statement, led by Freedom House, urging the U.S. Congress to advance the Transnational Repression Policy Act and hold markup sessions on the bipartisan bill, which would better protect people in the U.S. from foreign governments targeting dissidents abroad.

Xi Jinping Visit to the US



Xi Jinping arrived in Washington for his Sept. 24 state visit, HRF projected the faces and names of eight political and religious prisoners onto prominent buildings across the nation's capital — including the National Gallery and local bridges — so the dictator would see the people his regime imprisons. The campaign, built on HRF's "symbolic resistance" creative concept pairing tightly cropped portraits with symbols of each prisoner's profession, featured figures such as Owen Chow (Hong Kong 47), Ilham Tohti, artist Gao Zhen, Joshua Wong, and three persecuted pastors. It ran alongside a CCPDI-led open letter to Xi and HRF's transnational-repression policy briefs published ahead of the visit.

CCP Disruption Initiative



Policy Briefs & Toolkit

In August, CCPDI published two policy briefs (US and EU) and an activist toolkit against China's transnational repression — released deliberately before Xi Jinping's September visit to Washington.

Korea Desk

The Korea Desk is dedicated to challenging Kim Jong-un's oppressive regime. Throughout 2026, HRF built and strengthened collaborations with local activists, civil society groups, and international organizations to improve human rights conditions in North Korea. It also devised new strategies to expose North Koreans to realities beyond the Kim regime's totalitarian "utopia."



NK Insider

NK Insider (NKIN) is the first English-language news platform featuring information, analyses, and op-eds about North Korea written by North Korean defectors. In 2026, NKIN published 20 defector-perspective articles in nine weeks, reaching 8,886 active users from 133 countries and 12,145 page views. In early 2026 the platform had already gained 18,000 users from 150 countries.

Microgrants

Korea Desk grants — \$96,000 across five Seoul-based organizations — ran through 2026, funding projects that increase public awareness of North Korea's human rights situation and support the flow of information into and out of the country, with final deliverables completed in December. These initiatives have taken on heightened importance in the wake of U.S. funding cuts and South Korea's tightening restrictions on information flow into North Korea.

Flash Drives for Freedom

Flash Drives for Freedom (FDFF) is a multi-award-winning program that aims to free the minds of North Koreans from the regime's pervasive propaganda and help them become critical consumers of information. From May–June, 750 USB drives were delivered to NK Times partner networks in Northeast China, and 1,000 drives made it into North Korea — reaching Hyesan, Pyongyang, Nampo, Sariwon, and Haeju with news, films, and educational content. Reporting confirms mixed content is safer and more effective than purely political material.



Oslo Scholars × Korea Desk

From June–August, three Oslo Scholars contributed to FDFF promotion and monitoring and produced two research reports — including "Communication Technologies for Engaging Citizens in North Korea: A Viability Assessment."

Korea Desk

NK Insider Forum

NK Insider's June 1–July 30 window saw 20 defector-perspective articles reach 8,886 active users from 133 countries and 12,145 page views. In December, final deliverables are due from the five 2025-cycle Korea Desk grantees — Korea Campus Crusade for Christ, Lumina, NK Times, North Korean Writers in Exile PEN Center, and Vision North — spanning internal documents, footage, analytical articles, public-awareness videos, educational outcomes, and final reports.

On Nov. 19, HRF hosted the NK Insider Forum in Seoul, featuring defectors Jang Seiul and Park Sang-hak. Now in its third year, the forum convenes defectors, diplomats, and civil society to confront censorship inside North Korea and reinvigorate global engagement on North Korean human rights.



Confronting tyranny requires the support of communities and industries across the world.

Through public education initiatives and events, including the Oslo Freedom Forum conference series, HRF aims to engage and unite a global audience in the struggle against tyranny.

Public Education & Events



Oslo Freedom Forum



The Oslo Freedom Forum (OFF) is a global conference series that brings together the world's most prominent human rights defenders and industry leaders to exchange valuable tools, knowledge, and resources in the struggle for basic rights and individual liberties.

HRF returned to Oslo, Norway, from June 1–3 to host the 18th annual OFF. This year's theme, "Dismantling Dictatorship," reflected a simple truth: authoritarian regimes are built on fear, myth, and captured institutions — but they can be taken apart with strategy, solidarity, and ingenuity. Nearly 1,600 participants from 111 countries attended — a record for in-person participation and a 26% increase over the previous year — with 113 speakers. HRF provided complimentary tickets, flights, and hotels for 40 activists who otherwise could not have attended, and sold 80 discounted student tickets.

Theater Talks

Speakers included Nobel Peace Prize laureate María Corina Machado, who addressed the forum in person for the first time after years of joining remotely and pressed for new elections in Venezuela; Telegram CEO Pavel Durov; actor and humanitarian Richard Gere; Iranian advocate Noor Pahlavi; Belarusian opposition leader Sergey Tihanovski; former Georgian President Salome Zourabichvili; Salvadoran legislator Claudia Ortiz; Angolan dissident rapper Luaty Beirão; Qatari whistleblower Abdullah Ibhaiz; Crimean Tatar activist Lia Gazi; and Oslo Mayor Anne Lindboe, among many others.





Interactive Programming

Through panel discussions, fireside chats, and workshops, interactive programming challenged participants to think more critically and create practical, innovative solutions to advance freedom — including the Freedom Tech Academies, which brought Bitcoin education to attendees and shared HRF's new Bitcoin for Nonprofits guide.



Global Impact

OFF 2026 generated more than 1,000 media hits across 125+ countries in 27 languages, 7.7 million video views, and 350,000 social media engagements.



Spotlight spread

The Thulani Maseko Justice Prize

The Thulani Maseko Justice Prize recognizes courageous human rights lawyers who risk, or have risked, their lives to defend the rule of law and democracy. The Maseko Prize honors the late Swazi human rights lawyer, renowned democracy advocate, and former OFF speaker, Thulani Maseko, who was assassinated in his home on Jan. 21, 2023.

This year's Maseko Prize laureate is Rocío San Miguel, a Venezuelan lawyer, anti-corruption activist, human rights defender, and founder of the NGO Control Ciudadano, dedicated to the monitoring of the activities of armed and security forces. Her work has made her a long-time target of harassment and persecution by the regimes of Hugo Chávez and Nicolás Maduro. San Miguel has been arbitrarily detained since Feb. 9, 2024, and was accused of terrorism in a sham process in which no evidence was ever provided, triggering worldwide condemnation and calls for her release from the UN and the Inter-American Commission of Human Rights.

The Václav Havel Prize for Creative Dissent

The Havel Prize is awarded to dissidents who unmask the lies of dictatorship through art.

The Human Rights Foundation founded the Václav Havel International Prize for Creative Dissent in collaboration with Dagmar Havlová, widow of the late poet, playwright, philosopher, statesman, and former HRF Chairman Václav Havel, following his death in December 2011.

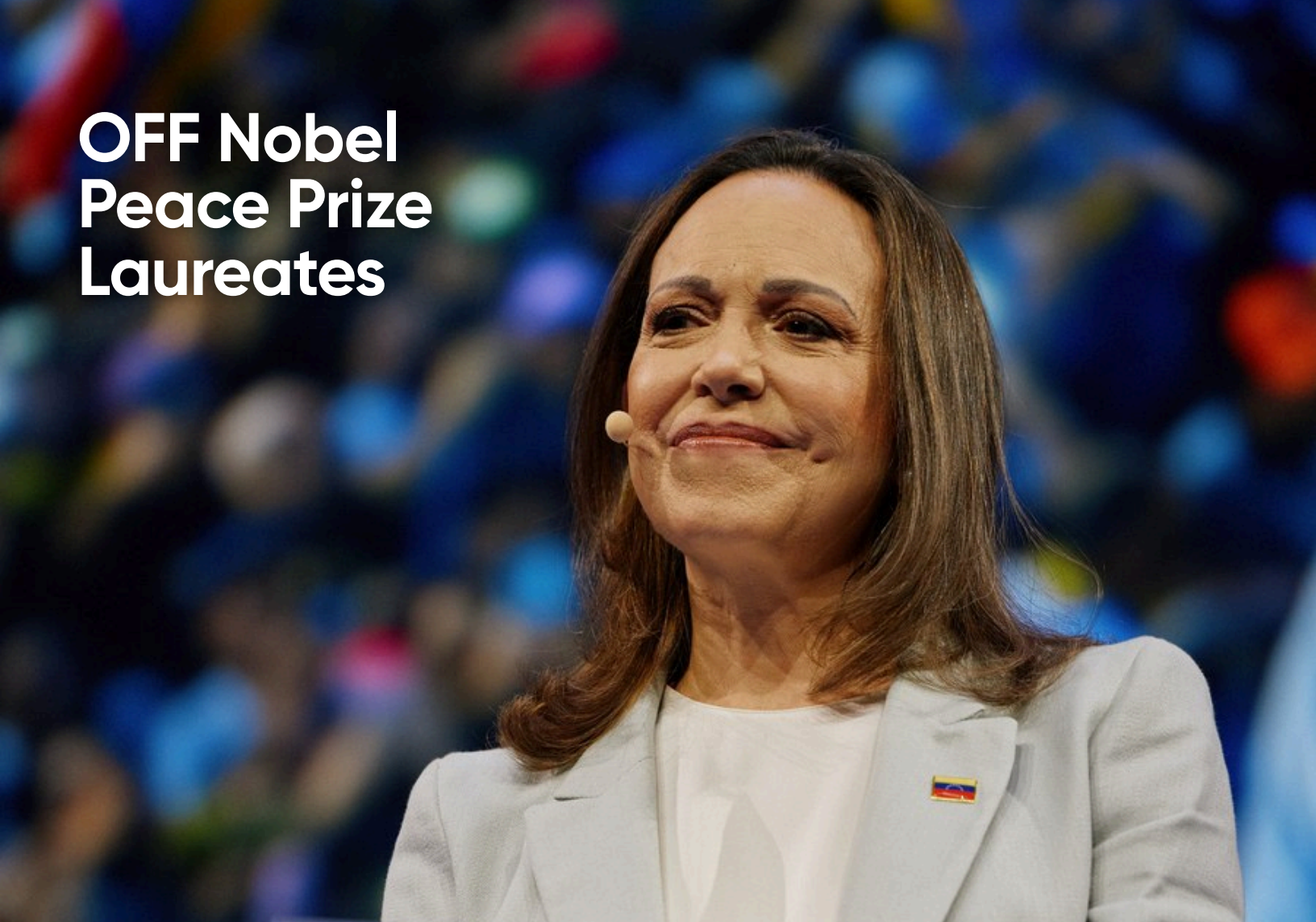
The Václav Havel International Prize for Creative Dissent celebrates those who, with bravery and ingenuity, unmask the lie of dictatorship by living in truth. For Václav Havel, living in truth meant an unwavering commitment to living according to one's belief in democracy and civil liberties. The Prize was founded in 2012 to honor Havel for his lifelong dedication to promoting and protecting individual rights.



2026 Laureates: Gao Zhen & Sai

At the 2026 Oslo Freedom Forum, HRF awarded the Václav Havel International Prize for Creative Dissent to Chinese contemporary artist and prisoner of conscience Gao Zhen — one half of the Gao Brothers duo, recently sentenced by the Chinese regime — and to Burmese dissident artist and curator Sai (who works under a pseudonym for the safety of himself and his family). Both laureates were recognized for unmasking the lies of dictatorship through art at great personal risk.

OFF Nobel Peace Prize Laureates



On Dec. 10, 2025, María Corina Machado was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize for mobilizing millions through peaceful civic action and emerging as the central figure of Venezuela's democratic movement, despite facing political disqualification, threats, and sustained persecution by the regime. Machado spoke at the Oslo Freedom Forum in the run-up to the 2024 elections — and in June 2026, six months after receiving the prize in Oslo, she returned to the OFF stage in person, pressing for new elections in Venezuela and reminding the world that democracy is both fundamental to peace and worth the sustained struggle against fear and tyranny.

María Corina Machado is the fifth Nobel Peace Prize laureate to have spoken at HRF's flagship conference prior to winning the prize.



Ales Bialiatski.
2022 laureate, for decades of championing human rights and democracy in Belarus. Bialiatski was released from prison in Belarus at the end of 2025.



Oleksandra Matviichuk,
2022 laureate, for her work with the Center for Civil Liberties documenting war crimes and human rights abuses during Russia's invasion of Ukraine.



Dr. Denis Mukwege,
2018 laureate, for his work treating survivors of conflict-related sexual violence in the Democratic Republic of Congo and advocating for justice for victims.



Leymah Gbowee,
2011 laureate, for organizing Christian and Muslim women in a peace movement that helped end the dictatorship of Liberian warlord Charles Taylor.

College Freedom Forum

The College Freedom Forum (CFF) is an event series held on university campuses, designed to connect students with world-renowned activists working to promote democracy and human rights in countries ruled by authoritarian regimes. Through keynote talks, panels, and interactive sessions, students engage with today's most pressing human rights issues. CFF equips students with new perspectives on their academic studies and inspires future careers in human rights, journalism, public policy, business, and beyond.



Seton Hall University



HRF hosted a CFF at Seton Hall University on Feb. 20, 2026, in collaboration with the School of Diplomacy and International Relations. Themed "Lessons from Tibet on Repression and Nonviolent Resistance," the event featured Tibetan activist and World Liberty Congress spokesperson Chemi Lhamo, who shared her journey of exile, community-driven resistance, and her experience surviving transnational repression — including the doxxing and threat campaign she faced while running for student union president at the University of Toronto. Students engaged with Lhamo through keynote talks and roundtables exploring nonviolent movements against authoritarian and colonial powers.

College Freedom Forum Berlin



HRF hosted its first-ever European CFF in Berlin on Sept. 25, 2026, at Alte Münze, in partnership with the Prometheus Institute and its Open Summit — marking CFF's expansion beyond the U.S. and Latin America. The event featured Chloe Cheung (Hong Kong pro-democracy activist), Dr. Zohreh Abdollahkhani (Chair, Human Rights for Sport), Pedro Urruchurtu (International Affairs Coordinator, Vente Venezuela, who spent more than 400 days in political confinement), and Tanele Maseko (Swazi activist and widow of assassinated human rights lawyer Thulani Maseko). Together with the Open Summit the following day, the events convened the next generation of leaders to explore how freedom can be advanced in Germany and around the world.

HRF at Global Events

Throughout 2026, HRF took to the global stage, participating in and convening key international events to amplify the conversation around human rights and liberal democracy.

Event logos

Project 2140 | Nosara, Costa Rica | Jan. 6–9

AI Hack for Freedom | Austin, TX | Jan. 16–18

BLISS | Nosara, Costa Rica | Feb. 2–5

Geneva Summit for Democracy | Geneva, Switzerland | Feb. 18

College Freedom Forum | Seton Hall University, NJ | Feb. 20

Dialogues on Democracy | Munich, Germany | Feb. 24

Tyranny Tracker Launch | New York, NY | Feb. 26

SXSW & Vibe Coding for Freedom | Austin, TX | Mar. 16–18

Beyond Borders Activist Retreat | Ghent, Belgium | Mar. 23–26

EG Justice Retreat | Madrid, Spain | Mar. 26–29

Freedom Fellows Working Retreat | Brussels, Belgium | Mar. 28–Apr. 4

AI Hack for Freedom II | Nashville, TN | May 8–10

Oslo Freedom Forum | Oslo, Norway | June 1–3

Africa Liberty Forum | Accra, Ghana | July

Resilience Retreat | Blue Spirit, Costa Rica | Aug. 8–15

Freedom Fellowship Retreat | Panama City, Panama | Sept. 19–26

Agent Camp VII & AI Hack III | Washington, D.C. | Sept.

Freedom Tech DC | Bitcoin Policy Institute, Washington, D.C. | Sept. 22–23

College Freedom Forum | Berlin, Germany | Sept. 25

Global Freedom Tech Summit | Nashville, TN | Oct. 6–9

Forum 2000 | Prague, Czechia | Oct. 11–13

Thulani Maseko Justice Prize | The Hague, Netherlands | Oct.

AI for Individual Rights Summit | San Francisco, CA | Nov. 3–5

NK Insider Forum | Seoul, South Korea | Nov. 19

Africa Bitcoin Conference | Blantyre, Malawi | Dec. 1–5

AI Hack for Freedom VI | San Francisco, CA | Dec. 2-4

Art in Protest installation | Art Week Miami | Dec.

George Ayittey Democracy Retreat | Africa | Dec.

George Ayittey Democracy Retreat

George Ayittey Democracy Retreat

In December 2026, HRF assembled activists from across Africa for the fifth edition of the George Ayittey Democracy Retreat, a private convening of select African democracy champions in honor of late HRF International Council member and former Oslo Freedom Forum speaker Dr. George Ayittey.

Looking Ahead (Sept–Dec)

The final quarter will be especially busy for the Combating Kleptocracy team: panels and keynote speeches in Munich, Prague, and the Dominican Republic; reports on corruption in Nicaragua, Angola, El Salvador, Serbia, and Cameroon, plus the NBA's relationship with authoritarians; and the Storython in Lisbon, Portugal — a September convening bringing together anti-corruption activists from Central Africa to examine new ways to investigate and highlight the threats of corruption and kleptocracy.

Online Activist Academy

The Online Activist Academy is a self-paced online course tailored for activists and civil society leaders defending human rights and democracy within authoritarian regimes. This comprehensive course is designed to provide participants with valuable skills and theoretical knowledge to increase the impact of their advocacy efforts. This comprehensive course, spanning 10 modules, is designed to provide participants with valuable skills and theoretical knowledge to increase the impact of their advocacy efforts. All the modules include closed captions in English, Russian, Arabic, Spanish, and French.

Through the Academy, activists:

- Develop a thorough understanding of effective nonviolent strategies for human rights advocacy in authoritarian regimes
- Acquire practical skills to enhance advocacy and outreach initiatives
- Explore theoretical frameworks to increase their understanding of nonviolence theory, digital security, social media, fundraising, mental health, and more.

In countries ruled by authoritarian regimes, the work of individual activists and civil society organizations often proves more impactful than that of large intergovernmental and nongovernmental entities.

For this reason, HRF provides direct support to those on the frontlines of freedom and democratic reform. Its support comes in many forms, including mentorship programs, networking opportunities, technical support, and financial aid, all designed to empower and sustain these courageous efforts.

Direct Support



Microgrants

HRF's Microgrants program provides financial support to activists actively challenging tyranny.

Microgrants are given to select human rights activists and civil society leaders with demonstrated financial need. HRF tracks the impact of each microgrant and assists recipients in leveraging their funds to achieve the greatest change possible.

Image pending

2026 Grantees

HRF awarded \$15,000 to Students for a Free Tibet for the Tibetan Youth Tenshug — a global gathering honoring the Dalai Lama and investing in Tibet's future



HRF awarded \$10,000 to Vanguard Africa Foundation's "Tales of Resistance."

CCPDI microgrants supported the Hong Kong Fair in Malmö (Stand With Hong Kong EU) and grassroots diaspora advocacy.

HRF awarded \$15,000 to Abdullah Ibhais for "Inside the Machine," training journalists to counter sportswashing around the FIFA World Cup



Korea Desk granted \$96,000 across five Seoul-based organizations.

Venezuela Solidarity Fund

On July 28, 2024, the Venezuelan regime announced the fraudulent electoral victory of Nicolás Maduro, while the opposition campaign, led by presidential candidate Edmundo González Urrutia and María Corina Machado, credibly established victory by a wide margin. The regime's blatant corruption and fraud ignited a backlash at home and abroad. In response, the regime has kidnapped and disappeared opposition members, arrested journalists, and violently repressed protesters, refusing to accept defeat.

In response, HRF created the Venezuela Solidarity Fund to provide direct financial assistance to courageous, nonviolent individuals and local organizations in Venezuela working tirelessly to document the regime's abuses and secure a peaceful transition to democracy.

Belarus Solidarity Fund

HRF's Belarus Solidarity Fund (BSF) was launched in 2020 amid the protests against Alexander Lukashenko's regime. BSF has since supported the country's pro-democracy movement, providing a lifeline to those targeted for their political beliefs, including activists, political prisoners, and striking workers. HRF raises awareness of the situation in Belarus and partners with local leaders of the Belarusian diaspora, establishing fundraisers to assist victims of political repression and various humanitarian initiatives.

2025 Grants

Center for Belarusian Solidarity | Belarus & Ukraine

HRF awarded a microgrant to the Center for Belarusian Solidarity to operate a supplementary education school to assist Belarusian children living in Poland as a result of the repression and persecution that followed Belarus's 2020 elections. The center serves Belarusian and Ukrainian children and employs teachers from both countries.

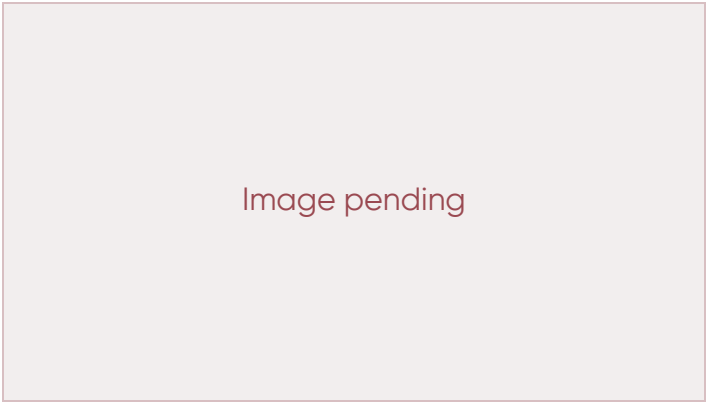
HRF's Help Ukraine Fund

HRF established the Help Ukraine Solidarity Fund in March 2022, days after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, to provide humanitarian aid to citizens trapped in the conflict zone and expose Putin's global war on freedom. Throughout 2025, HRF sought to raise awareness of Russia's ongoing assault on democracy and provided grants to organizations assisting Ukrainians and their cause.

The Freedom Fellowship network now counts 76 leaders across 37 countries — including HRF's first Fellows from El Salvador and Mozambique — following the eighth cohort's convening at OFF 2026.

Freedom Fellowship

HRF's Freedom Fellowship is a one-year program that gives human rights advocates, social entrepreneurs, and nonprofit leaders from challenging political environments the opportunity to increase the impact of their work. Through mentorship and hands-on training sessions, fellows develop critical skills and join a growing community of human rights activists.



Eighth Cohort Convenes

The new class met at OFF in June, growing the network to 76 leaders across 37 countries — including HRF's first Fellows from El Salvador and Mozambique — and began with digital-security mentorship from John Shaffer. A working retreat in Panama City followed in September.

2026 Working Retreat in Brussels

From Mar. 28–Apr. 4, nine 2025–26 Fellows — from Bangladesh, Belarus, Nicaragua, Russia, South Sudan, the Uyghur Region, and Venezuela — received 30+ hours of training at a working retreat in Brussels in leadership, fundraising, mental health, public speaking, Bitcoin, AI, and vibe coding, and met the European Parliament's Subcommittee on Human Rights.



Alumni in the Spotlight

2019 alumnus Netiwit Chotiphatphaisal's Sam Yan Press was shortlisted for the 2026 Prix Voltaire; after he became the first Thai imprisoned for conscientious objection to conscription, 18 Fellowship alumni signed an open letter in his defense.

Graduation at OFF 2026

The 2025–26 cohort finished with Ignite Talks public-speaking mentorship and life coaching from Lilian Tintori, culminating in capstone presentations in Oslo — including Zumretay Arkin's talk on the Uyghur cause.

Building Resilience & Well-Being

In an increasingly challenging world, the resilience and well-being of activists have never been more crucial. Activists often face significant emotional, mental, and physical demands, making it essential to prioritize their well-being. HRF supports its global community through unique wellness retreats, trauma workshops, and other resources. By investing in the strength and vitality of activists, HRF ensures that their work can continue to drive impactful, lasting change.

In February, HRF secured first-year funding with a three-year commitment, launching the Resilience program in partnership with Dr. Elissa Epel of UC San Francisco — whose stress-and-resilience research will shape a landmark study of activist durability.

International Trauma Conference



Resilience headlined the Trauma Research Foundation's Boston International Trauma Conference, introduced on the main stage by Jhanisse Vaca-Daza and Alexia Tovar following Dr. Bessel van der Kolk's opening.

Peer-to-Peer Support Session

Monthly peer-to-peer support sessions launched, the first for Venezuelan activists after the June earthquake. These will continue to spread to activists around the world.

Inaugural Retreat



From Aug. 8–15, approximately 20 frontline defenders gathered at Blue Spirit in Nosara, Costa Rica for a trauma-informed week of rest, reflection, and peer support — with faculty including Annette Knopp, Dr. Vanina Waizmann, and Gayle Karen Young, plus mentorship from Lilian Tintori. A 10–15 minute documentary was produced.



Oslo Scholars



The Oslo Scholars program offers university students the opportunity to intern with some of the world's leading human rights defenders and activists. HRF matches students with past Oslo Freedom Forum speakers and Freedom Fellows based on their regional knowledge, language abilities, and thematic interests for a summer-long internship.

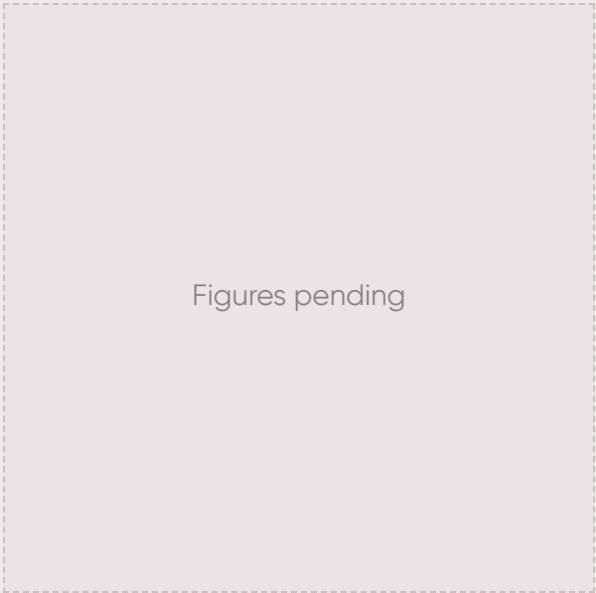
In 2026, from 289 applications, 55 students were placed at 17 civil society organizations worldwide — from investigating Kremlin corruption at the Anti-Corruption Foundation to tracking far-right extremism. In June, 52 Scholars — the largest class ever — began their internships, with three sponsored to work in-person with mentors in at-risk environments for the first time.



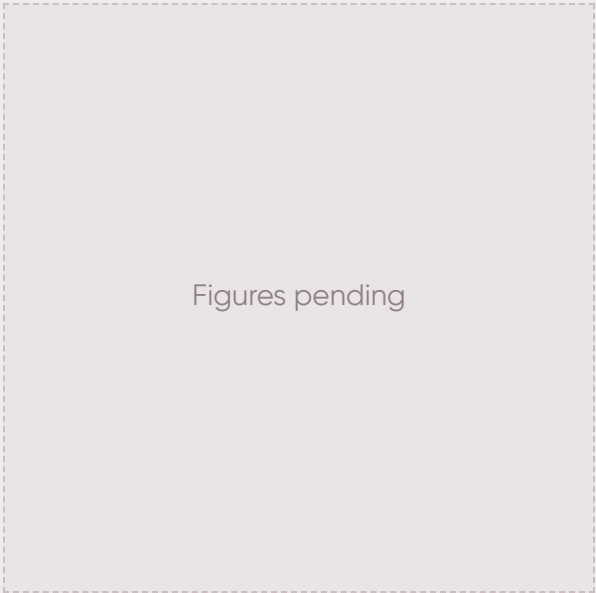
2025

Expenses

Figures pending



Comparative figures pending

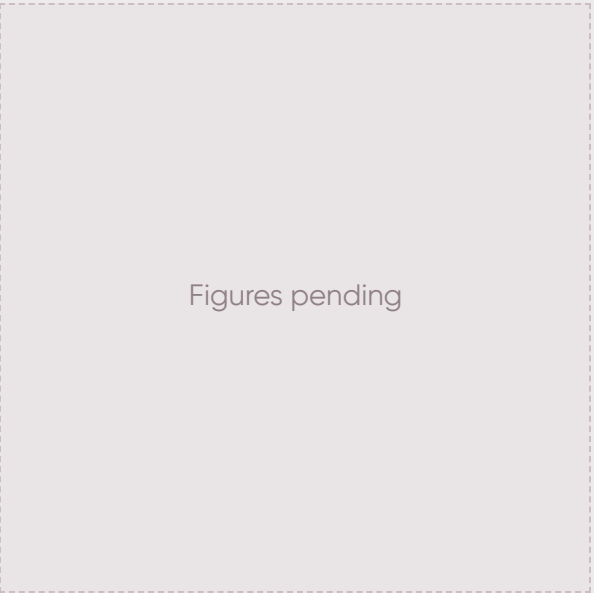


Financial figures pending review

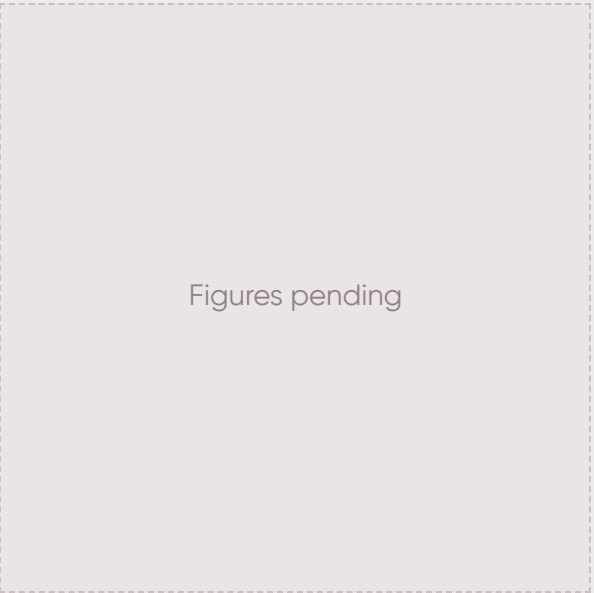
2025

Revenue

Figures pending



Comparative figures pending



Ali Al-Bayaa,
Research Fellow

Gloria Ampofo,
Travel Logistics Coordinator

Nick Anthony,
CBDC Tracker Fellow

Samuele Arioli,
Tyranny Tracker Intern

Mariana Atala,
Legal & Policy Fellow

Holly Baxter,
Executive Director, Art in Protest

Emilia Bebić,
Program and Research Fellow

Claudia Bennett,
Legal and Program Officer

Céline Assaf-Boustani,
President

Sophia Choi,
Junior Designer

Kristen Clemens,
Policy and Research Officer

Matthew Correa,
Financial Freedom Digital Growth Intern

Judy Imasuen,
Bitcoin Development Operations Consultant

Alessandro De Nino,
Comptroller

Tahlia Edgar-Chalker,
Associate Producer/Editor

Javier El-Hage,
Chief Legal Officer

Per Elvestuen,
Oslo Freedom Forum Director

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In Memoriam

Memorial feature pending

Additional memorial copy pending



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Program Updates

January 2026: HRF sponsored the first AI Hack for Freedom at Bitcoin Park, a campus in Austin, Texas, dedicated to free and open-source software. The hackathon paired eight dissidents from Venezuela, Russia, China, and other countries ruled by authoritarian regimes with top open-source developers to build tools addressing activists' most urgent needs through vibe coding. A prize pool of one bitcoin was distributed to winners, with honoraria split equally across remaining teams.

March 2026: At SXSW 2026, HRF hosted a panel discussion titled “Encrypted Resistance: Youth Revolt in Memes, Art & Metadata,” exploring how coded memes, guerrilla art, and youth creativity fuel encrypted resistance and reshape protest across the digital firewall. The panel featured Xiao Qiang, founder and editor-in-chief of China Digital Times; Eva Galperin, director of cybersecurity at the Electronic Frontier Foundation; and Angelo Sathayu Sathorn, a Thai youth movement leader. HRF also hosted the ESC TYRANNY booth, which showcased how activists around the world use AI to power their movements and invited visitors to create their own websites to resist authoritarianism, and sponsored a side event exploring how authoritarian regimes weaponize AI and how freedom technology can help activists push back against repression.

Media Highlights

February 2026: The Express Tribune (Pakistan) — “India accused of using legal process as punishment.”

March 2026: Citizen TV Kenya feature on HRF's work.

January 2026: TV 2 (Norway) — Elites sit in Oslo and discuss “respect for the prize.”

March 2026: TV 2 (Norway) — New index gives US answer: Most worried about this.

March 2026: Minerva (Norway) — “Putin bombs the power grid. The children continue to play.”

Freedom Fellows in the News

March 7, 2026: Nikkei — “Uyghur leader looks to Japan's Takaichi to help counter China pressure,” featuring Freedom Fellow Zumretay Arkin.

